

The Lighthouse Keeper

Mara had kept the light for eleven winters, and in that time she had learned to read the weather the way other people read faces. A change in the wind before dawn meant fog by noon; a certain stillness in the gulls meant a storm was still two days off, gathering its strength somewhere past the horizon she could not see.

Tonight the stillness was wrong. She stood at the gallery rail long after the lamp had caught, watching the dark water for a shape that would not resolve itself into a wave or a rock or anything she had a name for.

By the time the sun came up she had convinced herself it was nothing, the way she convinced herself of a great many things that winter. The supply boat was not due for another eleven days, and the radio had been silent since Tuesday, which was not unusual and which she chose not to think about too closely.

She made coffee. She wound the clockwork that turned the lens. She wrote the night's weather in the log in her small, careful hand, the same hand she had used for eleven years, and if it shook slightly this morning she did not write that down.